

Is LMMS totally open source?

The system has been built using open source tools. It is a customised application built using Java openlayers. The algorithms part of the project is open source. The mobile app component is also open source. The rest of the solution is specific to users or local geographic conditions. The team is working on building a generic model and bringing it into the open source domain.

Why open source?

Gollapalli feels that the team chose open source technologies as these help to build customised solutions. It is a multi-disciplinary project that requires the synchronisation of various aspects, and open source is best suited for that.

Who benefits from all this

The main beneficiaries of mapping surface water bodies seasonally will be people living in areas prone to climate changes. Gollapalli says, “We

are yet to reach a stage where the data that we are generating is directly useful for them. We are using a three-pronged approach in getting this to the grassroots level. We are working with NGOs and helping them understand the utility of open data and open source for water conservation. We are also working with the state government to create data platforms for analysis and planning, and enabling researchers to use satellite data, process it and contribute to open data.”

Dr K.S. Rajan, professor at IIIT Hyderabad and mentor to the team, adds, “There are three parts to the project—understanding the problem and designing a solution, executing the solutions that can be made operational, and training the staff (who can not only use the solution, but also maintain it and put it in practice on a day-to-day basis). My role consisted of helping to design the solution – looking at what data was

available – and working out the correct technical applications. Once that was done, we started building a prototype. And then we trained the right people in a government agency to involve them in the working of the solution.”

Future plans

So, what is the roadmap for this project? Gollapalli says, “After providing support to the government for three years and handing the project over to them, we plan to map and monitor all the surface water bodies in the Deccan plateau by collaborating with academic institutions and citizen groups.

“We have started an e-learning platform called SEED to help young researchers learn how to map changes in land resources by using satellite data. This platform will be part of a participatory GIS model that helps users to learn and contribute to open data. This will enable availability of data for all regions and all seasons.” **END** 

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